

Lesson 5: Communicating to Win

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Few people would disagree. Communication is the cornerstone of success, whether you're in personal or professional settings. It's the lifeblood of any high-functioning team and a core principle in Pat's famous Definite Dozen leadership principles. Communication is more than just words. It's the bridge that connects team members. Clear and open communication builds trust, respect, and cooperation, whether it's face-to-face, virtual meetings, or written messages. Miscommunication can have severe consequences. When we fail to express ourselves clearly, it can lead to confusion, conflict, and missed opportunities.

Here at Tennessee, communication is key to everything that we do for a successful event, whether we're having 50 people for a private event or 100,000 people for a football game. Communication ultimately is what drives our success.

Earlier in my career, I realized how vital communication was. I was trying to do many things on my own, and I realized that teamwork and communication was going to bring all of our ideas together. By not communicating the entire plan to the entire team that was helping us, ultimately, I ended up taking more of the work on myself, dropping some of those balls, and ultimately it wasn't as successful as it was. In that, I learned to communicate with everybody, even somebody that may not be helping you or could have an opportunity to help you, still communicate with them because you never know where you might need them for us on a game day.

To give another example, let's say John was preparing for an important client presentation but only mentioned it casually to a few colleagues in passing. He didn't really provide any context or seek their input formally. Then the day before the presentation, he realized he needed more information and hastily sent out a request for feedback. However, most team members were unprepared to provide useful input on such a short notice. They didn't have enough context on what he was asking to be able to help out in a meaningful way.

Or let's say his colleague Marcy had a major project she was working on and sent a brief, vague email to the team, assuming they would understand their roles and responsibilities. And the email lacked supporting details, such as the why or the overall goal of the project. Marcy entered all of the tasks into the project management system but never followed up to make sure everyone had received them or understood the instructions in the tasks. What kind of results do you think she got? You guessed it. The cost of miscommunication or under-communication can be high. You may have even experienced some of these outcomes yourself.

By contrast, over-communicating, especially when in doubt, is a powerful strategy to prevent miscommunication and bridge gaps in understanding. So is providing context. You may already be working several methods of this into your weekly rhythms, and that's great. Most teams use a variety of the following to make sure communication is running smoothly and flowing freely among the team:

Daily stand-ups: brief, focused meetings where the team shares progress, upcoming tasks, and any obstacles they are facing. This keeps everyone aligned and aware of each other's activities, allowing for quick problem-solving.

Regular feedback loops: regularly scheduled one-on-one meetings between team members and their managers provide a platform for constructive feedback.

Quick-time communication tools: using tools like Microsoft Teams, Slack, or Trello for ongoing communication and project management ensures that all team members can collaborate effectively, regardless of their location. Here at Tennessee, we use both Slack and Trello, and because we are all over the place and working on many different things, not worried about which email is the most recent, Slack, a real-time communication tool, helps us out tremendously.

Taking the time to communicate well at its core is a powerful mark of respect. Let's take a minute to learn more.